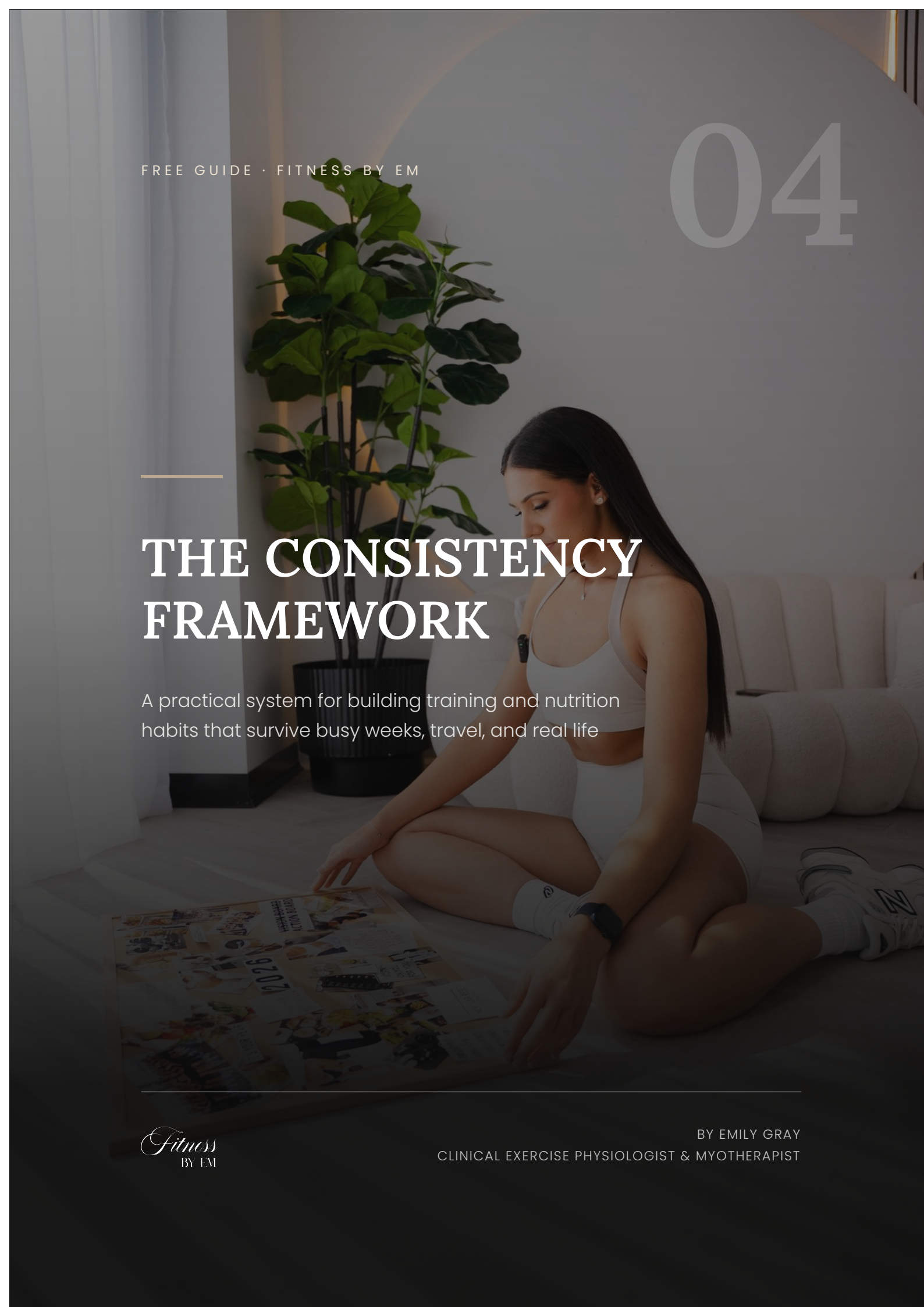


FREE GUIDE · FITNESS BY EM

04

THE CONSISTENCY FRAMEWORK

A practical system for building training and nutrition habits that survive busy weeks, travel, and real life

Fitness BY EM

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CONSISTENCY · ALL LEVELS

THE CONSISTENCY FRAMEWORK

A practical system for building training and nutrition habits that survive busy weeks, travel, and real life



80%	12wk	450+
TARGET CONSISTENCY	MINIMUM COMMITMENT	WOMEN COACHED

Introduction

You already know what to do. Eat enough protein, move your body, get some sleep, don't restrict so hard you rebound. Most women who come to me don't need more information, they've read the articles, watched the reels, own the meal prep containers.

What they're missing isn't knowledge, it's a system that holds up when life gets in the way. Because it will. A busy work week, a sick kid, a holiday, a bad night's sleep, these aren't obstacles to your plan, they're simply what real life looks like, and any plan that can't absorb them was never going to last.

This guide gives you the framework I use with clients to build consistency that survives the messy weeks, not just the easy ones.

1. Why Motivation Fails And Habits Win

Motivation is a feeling. It fluctuates based on your sleep, your stress, your mood, the weather, whether something exciting happened that day. Building a long-term plan on top of something this unreliable is why so many attempts collapse the moment life gets stressful, which is exactly when you need consistency most.

Habits work differently. A habit is a behaviour that's become largely automatic, it doesn't require the same reserve of willpower and decision-making energy that a motivated action does. Brushing your teeth doesn't require motivation, you just do it, because it's wired in as a default behaviour.

The goal of this framework isn't to somehow generate endless motivation. It's to build enough structure and repetition that the actions you want, showing up to train, eating adequate protein, moving your body, become closer to automatic, so they don't collapse the first time motivation dips, which it inevitably will.

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2. The Minimum Viable Version

One of the biggest reasons consistency breaks down is that people only have one version of their plan, the full, ideal version, and when a busy or difficult week makes that version impossible, they default to doing nothing at all.

The fix is building a "minimum viable version" of your plan in advance, a scaled-down version you can fall back on during a hard week that still counts as progress.

- **Full version:** four gym sessions, home-cooked meals, 10,000 steps a day.
- **Minimum viable version:** two 20-minute home workouts, protein at each meal even if the rest is imperfect, and a 15-minute daily walk.

The minimum viable version isn't a failure state, it's a deliberate part of the plan. Doing the minimum viable version during a genuinely hard week keeps the habit alive and the momentum intact, which makes it far easier to return to the full version once things settle, rather than starting completely from zero.

3. Planning For Disruption, Not Just The Ideal Week

Most plans are built for a perfect week that rarely actually happens. A more realistic approach is to plan explicitly for disruption.

Before it happens, ask yourself: what does my plan look like if I'm travelling for work? What does it look like during a week I'm sick? What does it look like during the two weeks around Christmas?

Having pre-decided answers to these questions removes the need to make decisions in the moment, when you're tired, stressed, or out of your normal routine, which is exactly when willpower is at its lowest and old patterns are most likely to take over.

A simple travel template: bodyweight exercises or a hotel gym session if available, prioritising protein at each meal regardless of what else is on the menu, and walking whenever practical. It doesn't need to be your ideal training week, it needs to keep the thread of consistency unbroken.

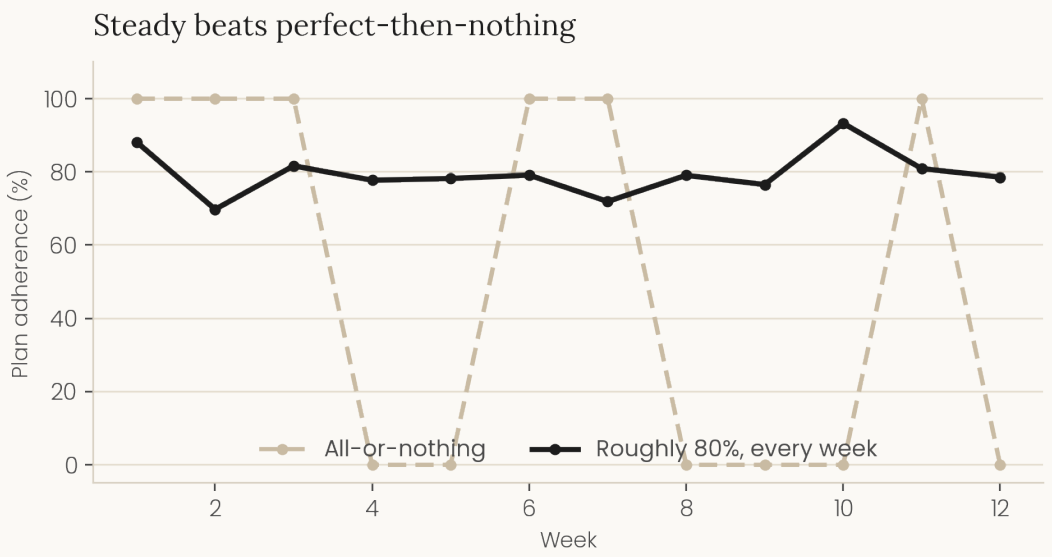
4. The 80/20 Approach

Aiming for 100% adherence, 100% of the time, sets an unrealistic standard that very few people, if anyone, can actually sustain long-term. And the all-or-nothing thinking that comes with a 100% standard is often what causes people to abandon the entire plan the moment they fall short of it.

A more sustainable target is roughly 80% consistency. That means if your plan calls for four training sessions a week, three actually completed most weeks is still a strong, sustainable result. If your nutrition target is hit most days but not every single day, that's success, not failure.

> *Aim for roughly 80% consistency, not 100%. That's the standard that actually survives a real life, and it's the one that lasts.*

This isn't about lowering your standards, it's about setting a standard you can actually maintain for months and years, rather than one that only survives a highlight-reel week with no disruptions. Consistent 80% effort sustained over a year will outperform sporadic bursts of 100% effort that collapse every few weeks.



Illustrative example: steady ~80% adherence outperforms all-or-nothing cycles over a 12-week block.

5. Building Triggers And Routines

Habits stick more easily when they're attached to an existing trigger or routine, rather than relying on remembering to do them from scratch each day.

Examples of habit stacking:

- "After I make my morning coffee, I'll take my supplements."
- "After I finish work, I'll change into my gym clothes before I sit down." This one is powerful, once you're dressed for the gym, going becomes far more likely than deciding from the couch.
- "Before I go to bed, I'll lay out tomorrow's gym clothes and prep my lunch."

Environment design matters just as much as the trigger itself. Keeping your runners by the door, pre-portioning snacks so they're grab-and-go, or having your gym bag packed the night before all remove small friction points that otherwise give your brain an opportunity to talk you out of the plan.

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6. Tracking Progress Without Becoming Obsessive

Some form of tracking is genuinely useful, awareness is a powerful tool for consistency. But tracking can tip into obsessive territory if it becomes a source of anxiety rather than information.

Useful, low-friction tracking: a simple checklist of your weekly non-negotiables (sessions completed, protein hit, water intake), a weekly bodyweight average rather than daily weigh-ins, and progress photos every few weeks.

Signs tracking has become unhelpful: checking the scale multiple times a day, feeling significant anxiety or guilt around a missed log, or letting one off-plan meal spiral into "I've ruined the whole week."

If tracking is adding stress rather than clarity, scale it back to the simplest version, sometimes just checking in with yourself weekly ("did I move my body most days, did I eat reasonably well, how do I feel") is enough.

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7. What To Do After A Setback

Every consistency journey includes setbacks, a missed week, an injury, a stretch of low motivation, a holiday that turned into two extra unplanned weeks off. What determines your long-term outcome isn't whether setbacks happen, they will, it's how quickly you return to your plan afterward.

The most important rule: one missed day or week does not need to become two. The moment you notice you've drifted, the goal is simply to return to your minimum viable version, not to "make up for it" with an extreme, unsustainable push that sets you up to burn out again.

Avoid the all-or-nothing trap of thinking a setback has "ruined" your progress. Progress isn't erased by a pause, it's only erased by permanently stopping. Treat every new day as a fresh opportunity to return to the plan, without needing to punish yourself for the days you didn't.



Emily Gray

Clinical Exercise Physiologist & Myotherapist. She's coached 450+ women through sustainable weight loss, and built Fitness By Em to give women the personalised, evidence-based coaching the fitness industry usually skips.

READY FOR MORE?

Work with Emily 1:1

This framework gives you the structure. What often makes the biggest difference is having someone in your corner, checking in, adjusting your plan for the weeks that don't go as planned, and helping you stay consistent when motivation naturally dips.

That accountability and personalisation is exactly what coaching provides.

Book a free 30-minute call to talk through what's made consistency hard for you in the past, and what a plan built around your actual life could look like.

Book a free call: calendly.com/emilygray81099/free-30min-consult-call
Instagram: instagram.com/_fitnessbyem_
Website: fitnessbyem.com.au

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